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Branding 101: The Importance of a Strong Logo



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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Every brand deserves a powerful logo. Every company needs a logo that is not only clear and on message, but also tells a story and evokes an emotional response. And being an affiliate marketer does not prevent you from enjoying the benefits of a strong brand.

Your logo is your first line of defense in consumer interpretation of your value as a marketer. Without a single word, a great logo speaks to your mission statement, is a summary of the potential customer's experience with your product or service and sets a standard of excellence to which the company can aspire.

In marketing, customer interpretation of your brand is all important. No matter what you sell, a product of your own or multiple products of others, you can increase sales and generate more leads through a powerful brand accompanied with a strong logo.

There are a few rules that may help a budding marketer when creating a logo of your own:

Simplicity



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A great logo reads at a distance. If it is not designed with simplicity in mind, a logo can appear muddy on a billboard. Even logos on the Web can easily become burdened by detail. The best examples offer a simple design while still conveying the brand's message.

The Nike "Swoosh" is a prime example of simplicity at its finest. Just stating the simple onomatopoeia "Swoosh" evokes everything Nike stands for. Their brand's message of action is represented through the interpretation of the logo, and the customer's understanding that using Nike's product will make them a more active and by extension, a healthier person. Essentially the logo tells consumers that using Nike products will help you live a better life - a strong message packed into a single curved line. By Nike's own admission, the logo is "[Simple. Fluid. Fast.](#)"

The story of the logo's creation is also something of interest. Carolyn Davidson, a Portland State University graphic design student, met Nike co-founder and chairman Phil Knight through her school and began working freelance jobs for him.

Ultimately, she delivered what became Nike's iconic logo to Knight for the princely fee of \$35 in 1971. By [adjusting for inflation](#) that meager amount comes to \$201.32 in 2013 dollars. Although in 1983, the story goes that Knight provided Davidson a gold diamond-encrusted Nike swoosh ring, and an envelope with an undisclosed amount of Nike stock. Not too shabby for a freelance gig by a college student!

Readable in a single color



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Another very important element to any logo is its readability. A key litmus test for any good logo is to paint it all one color. A simple logo can withstand nearly any augmentation of color. This is not to suggest that you deviate from your iconic color palate, but choose one of your company's main colors and coat your logo. If you lose readability, you've got a problem.

Look at Apple. Their logo once contained all the colors in the rainbow. This was a fine stylistic choice but ultimately unnecessary. The important core of the logo survived the stripping out of all colors and coating the logoblack. Suddenly the Technicolor apple became a symbol of simplicity, speaking to the underlying concepts behind any Apple product.

Theories abound about the bite taken out of the apple. Many thought the bite symbolized the fruit of knowledge in mid consumption, and in turn Apple was broadcasting the increased intelligence of their customers. Some have theorized that the bite is in reference to a byte, which is the cornerstone of the computing world.

In reality, during a [2009 interview with CreativeBits](#), Rob Janoff laid the mystery to rest. Much to the chagrin of those who have read volumes into that little logo, Janoff explains that "... the real reason why I did the bite it's kind of a letdown. But I'll tell you. I designed it with a bite for scale, so people get that it was an apple not a cherry."

Silhouette



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Now that you've stripped all the fancy colors out of your logo, remove everything but the outline. Fill in the outline and look at your logo as a silhouette. Look at it as if you are shining a flashlight through your logo and looking at its shadow on the wall. Is the skeleton of your logo still readable? Were those internal defining lines the crux of your readability? Consider changing those defining lines to negative space.

Microsoft took a wonderfully creative approach to streamlining and updating its logo. What was once a muddy logo of a window flying through the air is now four panes of glass facing straight forward. To delineate between Microsoft's main corporate logo and its flagship operating system, Windows, the four panes are tilted to a dynamic angle. For Microsoft's online search engine Bing, the company augmented those panes into a stylized "b," and Microsoft Office uses the same four panes, but they contort into an "O."

Many logo designers are split on Microsoft's success. Some, such as logo designer Sagi Haviv, think Microsoft's main corporate logo design is now too simplistic to be considered distinct. [Haviv explains to Mashable](#), "It needs to be unusual enough to persist in the mind. Those four squares - it's very inert. It just sits there. It has no motion, no tension - it's not dynamic in any way."

Haviv changes his tune with his dissection of the new Windows operating system logo, by adding, "That is fabulous because that is distinctive. It's still just as simple, but it burns in the mind. It doesn't look familiar. It will stay with you."

Multiple meanings

The challenge for the logo designer is to create an image that is simple yet distinct, clear and specific yet elusive enough to excite the viewer's imagination. Remember Apple's logo. That bite taken out was merely there for scale, but customers assumed otherwise, and Apple let them define its meaning.

This is a powerful tool in your arsenal of creating a strong brand through a logo that allows for consumer interpretation.

Ray Vellest at [webdesignerdepot.com](#) calls this "hidden meaning." He elaborates that, "Hidden meaning is not only about using negative space, but actually about exploring the concepts behind what make a logo unique."

Vellest also cites numerous great examples of big companies and their logos, [diving in to what they mean and the hidden expressions buried within](#).

Takeaway

Dating back to ancient Egypt, humanity has used powerful imagery to express complex ideas and stories that would normally have taken an entire wall of text. A logo is a marketer's first and best chance to convey a product's identity, and the consumer's relationship with product.

Make your logo speak volumes without uttering a word. If you create one that resonates with your target audience, you will be in a prime position to capitalize on the additional interest in you and what you're selling.

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